

## UNITED BY DIVERSITY. STRONGER AS ONE NIGERIA.

Tribalism is one of the greatest barriers to Nigeria's progress. It divides us, weakens our institutions, and robs our nation of its vast potential. But another Nigeria is possible—one built on justice, merit, fairness, peace, and shared prosperity.

How to Become a Detribalised Nigerian presents a ten-step roadmap for every citizen who desires a united nation. Through deep insights, real-life examples, reflection questions, and practical exercises, this book challenges every Nigerian to rise above prejudice and embrace the value of responsible citizenship.

This is more than a book. It is a call to conscience, a guide for transformation, and a blueprint for national renewal.

### IN THIS BOOK YOU WILL DISCOVER:

- ✓ The causes and consequences of tribalism in Nigeria
- ✓ Ten practical steps to becoming a detribalised Nigerian
- ✓ The role of education, the media, religion, leadership and institutions in building unity
- ✓ Lessons from other multi-ethnic countries
- ✓ A personal action plan and National Renewal Charter

*Nigeria's future depends on our choices today.  
Let us choose unity over division,  
service over selfishness, and nation over tribe.'*

ONE NATION  
ONE PEOPLE  
OUR FUTURE

HOW TO BECOME A DETRIBALISED NIGERIAN

Prof. Johnson Agharese Egonmwan

# HOW TO BECOME A DETRIBALISED NIGERIAN

A 10-STEP PRACTICAL GUIDE TO BUILDING  
A UNITED, PEACEFUL AND PROSPEROUS NATION



One People • One Nation • One Destiny

Prof. Johnson Agharese Egonmwan

*A better Nigeria begins with you!*

# STEP BY STEP OF BECOMING A DETRIBALIZED NIGERIA

Resyin Publications,  
Benin City, Edo State, NG  
C J.A. Egonmwan  
First Publication 2026

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be produced in any form or by any means without permission in writing from the author.

All Resyin titles are available at special quantity discounts for bulk purchases for sales promotions, educational. or institutional use. For details, write or phone the office of the Commercial Manger, Resyin (Nigeria) Consults Inc. P.O. Box 5774, Benin City, Edo State, Nigeria.

Email;; resyininconsults [1993@gmail.com](mailto:1993@gmail.com) Tel: +234 803 462 1513. Resyin Consults is the Academic and Consultancy Division of the Reysin (Nig) Co, Inc., a printing and publishing outfit registered in Nigeria.

ISBN:

Typeset in Cambria 13.5 pts by Resyin (Nig) Consults, 19, Igbihiyisi-Eweka Way, Off Ogba Road, GRA, Benin City, Edo State, Nigeria in collaboration with LAOADOF Publishers, 7, Majekodunmi Street,

Abesan Estate, Ipaja, Lagos State. Tel: .... 08038014588,  
08171003565.

Printed by LAOADOF Publishers.

## Table of Contents

Dedication

Acknowledgements

Preface

Introduction

Chapter 1: Understanding Tribalism in Nigeria

Meaning of tribe, ethnicity and nationalism

Historical origins

Tribalism versus cultural identity

Why tribalism persists

Chapter 2: The Costs of Tribalism

Political instability

Economic losses

Corruption and nepotism

Brain drain

Insecurity

Declining national cohesion

Chapter 3: Who Is a Detribalised Nigerian?

Characteristics of Patriotism above ethnicity

Fairness and justice

National consciousness

Chapter 4: Appreciating Nigeria's Diversity

Major and minority ethnic groups

Languages

Religions

Cultural richness

Diversity as national capital

Chapter 5: Step One Changing the Mindset

Identifying personal biases

Challenging stereotypes

Developing empathy

Replacing prejudice with understanding

Chapter 6: Step Two Building Cross-Cultural Friendships

Living beyond ethnic boundaries

Friendship, marriage and professional networks

Learning from other cultures

Chapter 7: Step Three Learning Other Nigerian Languages

Benefits of multilingualism

Practical approaches

Promoting mutual respect

Chapter 8: Step Four—Rejecting Nepotism and Favouritism

Meritocracy

Ethical leadership

Fair recruitment

Equal opportunities

Chapter 9: Step Five—Practising Inclusive Citizenship

Rights and responsibilities

Civic participation

Community service

National symbols and values

Chapter 10: Step Six—Using Education to Fight Tribalism

Schools

Universities

Curriculum reform

Youth exchanges

Civic education

Chapter 11: Step Seven—Responsible Politics

Voting beyond ethnicity

Issue-based campaigns

Political accountability

National interest first

Chapter 12: Step Eight—Media, Social Media and Tribal Narratives

Fake news

Hate speech

Responsible communication

Digital citizenship

Chapter 13: Step Nine—Religious Institutions as Agents of National Unity

Interfaith dialogue

Peacebuilding

Shared values

National reconciliation

Chapter 14: Step Ten—Leadership by Personal Example

Family

Workplace

Community

|                                                                         |  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Public service                                                          |  |
| Everyday actions that build unity                                       |  |
| Chapter 15: Lessons from Other Multi-Ethnic Countries                   |  |
| Singapore                                                               |  |
| Rwanda                                                                  |  |
| Canada                                                                  |  |
| India                                                                   |  |
| What Nigeria can learn                                                  |  |
| Chapter 16: Building the Nigeria of Our Dreams                          |  |
| Constitutional values                                                   |  |
| National integration                                                    |  |
| Youth leadership                                                        |  |
| Shared prosperity                                                       |  |
| Chapter 17: A Personal Action Plan for Becoming a Detribalised Nigerian |  |
| Thirty practical commitments                                            |  |
| Daily habits                                                            |  |
| Measuring personal progress                                             |  |
| Becoming an ambassador of unity                                         |  |
| Chapter 18: Conclusion—One Nation, One Destiny                          |  |

|                                                                 |  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| National Renewal Charter                                        |  |
| Call to action                                                  |  |
| Hope for future generations                                     |  |
| Appendices                                                      |  |
| Appendix A: Nigerian Ethnic Groups                              |  |
| Appendix B: National Symbols                                    |  |
| Appendix C: Civic Responsibility Checklist                      |  |
| Appendix D: Personal Unity Assessment Questionnaire             |  |
| References                                                      |  |
| Glossary                                                        |  |
| Index                                                           |  |
| Distinctive Features of the Book                                |  |
| Practical "Step-by-Step" approach.                              |  |
| Nigerian examples and case studies.                             |  |
| Reflection questions at the end of each chapter.                |  |
| Figures, tables, and illustrations.                             |  |
| Inspirational quotations.                                       |  |
| Action checklists.                                              |  |
| Exercises for students, public servants, and community leaders. |  |

**DEDICATION**

This book is dedicated to every Nigerian who believes that our diversity is a source of strength rather than division.

It is dedicated to the countless men, women, and young people who, through their daily lives, demonstrate that character is superior to ethnicity, competence is greater than favoritism, and patriotism is more enduring than tribal loyalty.

I also dedicate this work to present and future generations of Nigerians whose dream is to build a nation where justice, fairness, equal opportunity, and mutual respect flourish across ethnic, religious, and regional boundaries.

May this book inspire all who read it to become ambassadors of national unity and champions of a truly detribalised Nigeria.

**ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS**

I give thanks to Almighty God for the wisdom, strength, and grace that made the writing of this book possible.

My sincere appreciation goes to scholars, public servants, community leaders, civil society organisations, and patriotic Nigerians whose ideas, experiences, and sacrifices have contributed to the ongoing search for national unity and sustainable development in Nigeria.

I acknowledge the many authors, researchers, and institutions whose publications on governance, public administration, leadership, conflict resolution, nation-building, and civic education have enriched the perspectives presented in this book.

Special appreciation is extended to my family, professional colleagues, students, and associates for their encouragement and support throughout my academic and professional journey.

Finally, I salute every Nigerian who continues to reject hatred, prejudice, and discrimination, choosing instead to promote peace, justice, tolerance, and national cohesion. They remain the true builders of the Nigeria we all desire.

## PREFACE

Nigeria is one of the most culturally diverse nations in the world. With hundreds of ethnic groups, numerous languages, and rich cultural traditions, the country possesses enormous human and natural resources capable of transforming it into one of the world's leading economies. Yet, this diversity has too often been manipulated for political, economic, and social advantage, resulting in mistrust, division, and avoidable conflict.

The challenge facing Nigeria is therefore not diversity itself but the failure to manage diversity fairly, inclusively, and patriotically.

The concept of becoming a detribalised Nigerian does not require anyone to abandon his or her culture, language, traditions, or legitimate ethnic identity. Rather, it calls for elevating national loyalty above narrow ethnic interests while respecting and celebrating cultural differences.

This book presents a practical, step-by-step guide for individuals, families, educational institutions, religious organisations, political leaders, public servants, and civil society organisations seeking to strengthen national unity and responsible citizenship.

Drawing from principles of public administration, leadership, governance, civic responsibility, and personal experience, the book provides practical actions that every Nigerian can take to reduce prejudice, encourage inclusion, promote merit, and build trust across ethnic and religious divides.

Nation-building begins not only with governments but also with individual citizens. Every Nigerian has a role to play in creating a peaceful, united, and prosperous nation.

It is my hope that this book will serve as both an educational resource and a practical handbook for promoting national integration, democratic values, and sustainable development.

## INTRODUCTION

Every nation faces defining challenges that shape its future. For Nigeria, one of the greatest challenges has been the persistent influence of tribalism on politics, public administration, economic opportunities, social relationships, and national development.

Since independence in 1960, successive governments have introduced various initiatives aimed at promoting national integration, including the Federal Character Principle, the National Youth Service Corps (NYSC), unity schools, and constitutional safeguards designed to foster inclusion. While these measures have achieved important successes, ethnic suspicion, discrimination, and sectional loyalties continue to affect many aspects of national life.

Becoming a detribalised Nigerian is not an event but a deliberate process of personal transformation. It begins with recognising unconscious biases, embracing fairness, respecting diversity, and placing national interest above ethnic, religious, or regional considerations.

A detribalised Nigerian values competence over connection, justice over favoritism, and service over self-interest. Such a citizen judges individuals by their integrity, ability, and character rather than by their ethnic origin or language.

This book adopts a practical, step-by-step approach. Each chapter introduces a specific stage in the journey towards becoming a detribalised Nigerian, combining thoughtful analysis with practical recommendations, reflective questions, and real-life examples relevant to contemporary Nigeria.

The central message is simple but profound: Nigeria's unity will not be secured solely through constitutional provisions or government policies. It will be secured when millions of Nigerians consciously choose to see one another first

as fellow citizens, sharing a common destiny and a collective responsibility to build a peaceful, just, and prosperous nation.

If every reader commits to applying even a few of the principles presented in this book, the cumulative effect can contribute significantly to strengthening national cohesion and laying a firmer foundation for sustainable development.

The journey to a greater Nigeria begins with each one of us.

## CHAPTER ONE

### UNDERSTANDING TRIBALISM IN NIGERIA

#### INTRODUCTION

Nigeria is one of the most culturally diverse countries in the world. With over 250 ethnic groups, more than 500 indigenous languages, and a rich blend of cultures, traditions, and religions, the country possesses tremendous potential for national greatness. Diversity, when properly managed, promotes creativity, innovation, peaceful coexistence, and economic prosperity. However, when diversity is exploited for selfish political or economic interests, it becomes a source of division and conflict.

One of the greatest obstacles to Nigeria's progress has been tribalism—the tendency to place ethnic loyalty above national interest. Tribalism has influenced politics, public administration, employment, business, education, and even personal relationships. It has weakened meritocracy, fuelled distrust, and slowed national development.

This chapter explains the meaning of tribalism, distinguishes it from cultural identity, examines its historical roots, and highlights why overcoming tribalism is essential for building a stronger and more united Nigeria.

#### What Is Tribalism ?

Tribalism is an attitude or practice in which individuals show excessive loyalty or preference to members of their own ethnic group while discriminating against or distrusting people from other ethnic groups.

Tribalism manifests itself in various ways, including:

Preferring one's ethnic group in employment and promotions.

Voting solely on ethnic considerations.

Awarding contracts based on tribal affiliation rather than competence.

Promoting stereotypes against other ethnic groups.

Excluding qualified persons because of their ethnic origin.

Unlike healthy cultural pride, tribalism encourages prejudice, favoritism, and discrimination.

### Tribalism and Cultural Identity

Every Nigerian has the right to be proud of his or her language, culture, customs, and traditions. Cultural identity enriches society and strengthens social bonds. Tribalism begins only when cultural identity is used to deny others equal opportunities or to promote hatred and exclusion.

A detribalized Nigerian celebrates his or her heritage while respecting the heritage of others. National unity does not require abandoning one's culture; it requires placing fairness, justice, and patriotism above ethnic prejudice.

Table 1.1: Cultural Identity versus Tribalism

Cultural Identity

Tribalism

Promotes pride in one's culture

Promotes superiority of one group over others

Respects other cultures

Discriminates against other ethnic groups

Encourages peaceful coexistence

Encourages suspicion and division

Supports national unity

Weakens national cohesion

Appreciates diversity

Rejects diversity

### Historical Roots of Tribalism in Nigeria

Nigeria's ethnic diversity predates colonial rule, with different kingdoms, emirates, and communities developing independently over centuries. Colonial administration later merged these diverse peoples into one political entity. While this created modern Nigeria, it also fostered competition for political power and public resources.

After independence, ethnic rivalry increasingly influenced elections, public appointments, and resource allocation. Political parties often developed strong regional bases, while public institutions sometimes reflected ethnic balancing rather than merit alone.

Although successive governments introduced measures to promote national integration, tribal sentiments have remained a recurring challenge.

### Why Tribalism Persists

Several factors continue to sustain tribalism:

**Political Manipulation:** Some politicians appeal to ethnic sentiments to gain support instead of presenting sound policies.

**Economic Competition:** Scarcity of jobs and resources often encourages people to favour members of their own ethnic group.

**Ignorance:** Limited interaction with other ethnic groups encourages stereotypes and misconceptions.

**Historical Grievances:** Past conflicts and perceived injustices sometimes reinforce mutual suspicion.

**Weak Institutions:** When public institutions fail to guarantee fairness and equal opportunity, people rely more heavily on ethnic networks.

### **The Consequences of Tribalism**

The effects of tribalism extend far beyond personal relationships.

It weakens national unity by creating unnecessary divisions among citizens.

It undermines meritocracy when appointments and promotions are based on ethnicity rather than competence.

It fuels corruption through nepotism and favoritism.

It discourages investment because instability reduces investor confidence.

It increases political tension and sometimes contributes to violent conflict.

Ultimately, tribalism slows economic growth and reduces Nigeria's ability to compete globally.

### **Why Becoming Detribalised Matters**

A nation develops when its citizens trust one another and work together toward common goals.

A detribalised Nigerian:

Judges people by character and competence.

Supports fairness in public life.

Promotes peaceful coexistence.

Respects every Nigerian regardless of ethnic origin.

Places national interest above sectional interests.

Such attitudes strengthen democracy, improve governance, encourage investment, and foster sustainable development.

### **Reflection Questions**

What unconscious ethnic biases might I hold?

Do I judge people primarily by their tribe or by their character?

Have I ever benefited from or contributed to tribal favoritism?

How can I become a stronger advocate for national unity?

### **Practical Exercise**

During the next month, intentionally engage with people from ethnic groups different from your own. Learn about their culture, traditions, and values. Reflect on how these interactions influence your perceptions and attitudes.

### **CHAPTER SUMMARY**

Nigeria's diversity is one of its greatest assets, but tribalism has often transformed that strength into a source of division. Understanding the nature, causes, and consequences of tribalism is the first step toward overcoming it. Becoming a detribalised Nigerian begins with recognising that while we belong

to different ethnic communities, we all share one nation and one common destiny.

Key Thought: "Our ethnic identities enrich us, but our shared Nigerian identity should unite us."

In Chapter Two, we shall examine "The Cost of Tribalism" , analysing its political, economic, social, and developmental consequences with Nigerian examples, figures, and tables.

## **CHAPTER TWO**

### **THE COST OF TRIBALISM**

#### **INTRODUCTION**

Every nation pays a price when citizens place sectional interests above the common good. In Nigeria, tribalism has imposed enormous political, economic, social, and developmental costs. These costs are often hidden because they are spread across many sectors of national life, yet they collectively slow progress and weaken public confidence in national institutions.

When appointments are made on the basis of ethnicity rather than competence, when elections are decided primarily by ethnic sentiment instead of policies, and when public resources are distributed unfairly, the entire nation bears the consequences. No ethnic group ultimately benefits from a system that undermines merit, justice, and accountability.

This chapter examines the major costs of tribalism and explains why overcoming it is essential for Nigeria's future.

#### **Political Costs**

One of the greatest casualties of tribalism is good governance. Political competition frequently shifts from debates about ideas, programmes, and leadership to contests based on ethnic identity.

The consequences include:

Election campaigns that exploit ethnic divisions.

Weak political parties built around personalities or regional interests.

Difficulty in building national consensus.

Political instability and distrust.

Reduced accountability, as leaders may receive support primarily because they share an ethnic background rather than because of their performance.

A healthy democracy requires citizens to evaluate leaders by integrity, competence, and vision—not by tribe.

### **Economic Costs**

Tribalism has serious economic consequences. When merit is sacrificed for ethnic favoritism, productivity declines and national wealth suffers.

Common effects include:

Reduced efficiency in public institutions.

Loss of talented professionals through discrimination.

Poor investment decisions.

Lower investor confidence.

Slower economic growth.

Merit-based recruitment and promotion create stronger institutions and a more competitive economy.

### **Table 2.1: Meritocracy versus Tribal Preference**

Merit-Based System

Tribal-Based System

Best person selected

Ethnic loyalty determines selection

Higher productivity

Lower efficiency

Encourages innovation

Discourages excellence

Builds public confidence

Creates resentment

Supports national development

Weakens institutions

Social Costs

Tribalism damages relationships among citizens. It creates suspicion, stereotypes, prejudice, and unnecessary barriers between communities

Its social consequences include:

Distrust among ethnic groups.

Discrimination in employment and housing.

Reduced social interaction.

Family resistance to interethnic marriages.

Increased tension within communities.

A united society is built on mutual respect, understanding, and shared citizenship.

Administrative Costs

Public administration functions best when decisions are guided by competence, professionalism, and fairness.

Where tribalism dominates:

Recruitment may ignore qualifications.

Promotions may become politicised.

Public confidence declines.

Institutional effectiveness suffers.

Corruption becomes easier to sustain through networks of favoritism.

Strong institutions depend on impartiality rather than ethnic considerations.

### **Security Costs**

National security is strengthened when citizens trust one another and cooperate with government institutions.

Persistent tribal divisions can:

Increase communal conflicts.

Encourage hate speech.

Weaken intelligence sharing.

Reduce cooperation with security agencies.

Create opportunities for criminal groups to exploit local tensions.

Peace and security require national solidarity.

### **Educational Costs**

Schools and universities should promote national integration. Tribal prejudice, however, may discourage collaboration, reduce student interaction, and reinforce stereotypes from an early age.

Educational institutions should encourage:

Cultural exchange programmes.

Inclusive student leadership.

Civic education.

Respect for diversity.

Equal opportunities for all students.

### **National Development Costs**

Development depends on unity, stability, and effective institutions.

Where tribalism prevails:

National projects may be opposed for ethnic reasons.

Public resources may be distributed inefficiently.

National planning becomes more difficult.

Foreign investment may decline.

Citizens lose confidence in government.

No nation achieves sustainable development while deeply divided against itself.

## Figure 2.1: How Tribalism Affects National Development



## Reflection Questions

In what ways has tribalism affected my workplace or community?

Have I ever remained silent when discrimination occurred?

What practical steps can I take to promote fairness?

How can I encourage younger Nigerians to value national unity above ethnic divisions?

## Chapter Summary

Tribalism carries heavy political, economic, administrative, social, educational, and security costs. It weakens institutions, discourages merit, reduces productivity, and undermines national cohesion. Nigeria's long-term prosperity depends on replacing ethnic favoritism with justice, competence, and equal opportunity. Building a detribalised nation is therefore not merely a moral responsibility—it is an economic, political, and developmental necessity.

**Key Thought:** "When merit replaces tribal preference, the whole nation becomes stronger."

The next chapter, Chapter Three: Who Is a Detribalised Nigerian?, will define the qualities, values, attitudes, and daily practices of a truly detribalised citizen, with practical examples and a self-assessment checklist.

## CHAPTER THREE

### WHO IS A DETRIBALISED NIGERIAN?

#### INTRODUCTION

The expression "detribalised Nigerian" has become popular in discussions about national unity, leadership, and citizenship. It is often used to describe individuals who relate to fellow Nigerians without prejudice or ethnic bias. However, becoming a detribalised Nigerian is more than merely having friends from different ethnic groups. It is a conscious way of thinking, living, and making decisions based on fairness, justice, competence, and patriotism.

A detribalised Nigerian does not deny or abandon his or her ethnic identity. Rather, such a person appreciates his or her cultural heritage while recognizing that every Nigerian deserves equal respect, dignity, and opportunity.

This chapter examines the qualities, attitudes, and values that define a detribalised Nigerian.

#### The Meaning of a Detribalised Nigerian

A detribalised Nigerian is a citizen who places the national interest above ethnic, regional, or sectional interests. Such a person judges others by their character, competence, integrity, and commitment rather than by their ethnic origin, language, or religion.

Being detribalised means embracing the belief that Nigeria belongs equally to all its citizens and that every Nigerian should enjoy equal rights and opportunities under the law.

### Characteristics of a Detribalised Nigerian

A detribalised Nigerian demonstrates the following qualities:

#### 1. Patriotism

Love for Nigeria comes before loyalty to ethnic or regional interests. Such individuals work for the peace, unity, and progress of the country.

#### 2. Fairness

They treat people equally regardless of tribe, religion, gender, or place of origin. Their decisions are guided by justice rather than favoritism.

#### 3. Respect for Diversity

They appreciate Nigeria's many cultures, languages, and traditions, recognizing that diversity enriches the nation.

#### 4. Commitment to Merit

Appointments, employment, promotions, and leadership positions should be based on competence, integrity, and performance rather than ethnic connections.

#### 5. Integrity

A detribalised Nigerian refuses to participate in discrimination, corruption, nepotism, or ethnic favoritism.

#### 6. National Responsibility

Such citizens participate actively in civic life by obeying the law, paying taxes where applicable, voting responsibly, and contributing to community development.

**Table 3.1: Attributes of a Detribalised Nigerian**

Attribute

Practical Expression

Patriotism

Places Nigeria first

Fairness

Treats everyone equally

Integrity

Rejects corruption and favoritism

Respect

Appreciates all cultures

Merit

Supports competence over connections

Service

Works for national development

Everyday Actions That Demonstrate Detribalisation

Becoming detribalised is reflected in everyday behaviour.

Examples include:

Speaking respectfully about every ethnic group.

Building friendships across cultural boundaries.

Opposing discrimination wherever it occurs.

Employing qualified persons regardless of ethnic background.

Voting for capable leaders rather than ethnic candidates.

Supporting policies that promote justice and equal opportunity.

Encouraging children to appreciate Nigeria's cultural diversity.

These daily actions gradually strengthen national unity.

Common Misunderstandings

Some people mistakenly believe that becoming detribalised means abandoning one's language or cultural traditions. This is incorrect.

A detribalised Nigerian:

Speaks and values his or her native language.

Celebrates cultural festivals.

Respects traditional institutions.

Preserves cultural heritage.

At the same time, such a person refuses to use culture as a basis for discrimination or exclusion.

Benefits of Becoming a Detribalised Nigerian

The benefits extend beyond the individual.

For the individual:

Wider friendships and professional networks.

Better leadership opportunities.

Increased trust and credibility.

Broader understanding of Nigeria.

For the nation:

Stronger national unity.

Better governance.

Reduced conflict.

Improved economic productivity.

Greater political stability.

Sustainable national development.

### **Figure 3.1: The Journey to Becoming a Detribalised Nigerian**

Self-awareness ↓ Respect for Diversity ↓ Fairness ↓ Merit -Based Decisions ↓  
National Unity ↓ Sustainable Development

#### **Self-Assessment Checklist**

Consider the following questions:

Do I judge people primarily by their character?

Am I comfortable working with people from every ethnic group?

Have I ever discriminated because of ethnicity?

Do I promote merit over favoritism?

Do I encourage unity in my family, workplace, and community?

Honest answers will reveal areas for personal growth.

#### **Reflection Questions**

Which quality of a detribalised Nigerian do I already possess?

Which areas require improvement?

How can I influence my family and friends to reject tribal prejudice?

What practical action will I take this week to promote national unity?

#### **Chapter Summary**

A detribalised Nigerian is not someone without cultural roots; rather, it is someone whose love for Nigeria is greater than ethnic prejudice. Such citizens value fairness, competence, justice, integrity, and national service. They understand that Nigeria's future depends on citizens who see diversity as a strength rather than a barrier.

Every Nigerian can begin this transformation through conscious daily choices. Becoming detribalised is not a destination reached overnight but a lifelong commitment to building a more united, peaceful, and prosperous nation.

Key Thought: "A truly detribalised Nigerian celebrates cultural diversity while standing firmly for justice, merit, and national unity."

Chapter Four: Appreciating Nigeria's Diversity will explore Nigeria's ethnic, linguistic, cultural, and religious richness, showing how diversity can become a powerful asset for national development rather than a source of division.

## CHAPTER FOUR

### APPRECIATING NIGERIA'S DIVERSITY

#### INTRODUCTION

Nigeria is often described as the "Giant of Africa" not only because of its population and economy but also because of its remarkable cultural diversity. The country is home to more than 250 ethnic groups, over 500 indigenous languages, and a rich variety of traditions, cuisines, music, festivals, and religious practices. This diversity is one of Nigeria's greatest national assets.

Unfortunately, many Nigerians know very little about cultures other than their own. Ignorance often breeds suspicion, while knowledge promotes understanding and respect. A detribalised Nigerian sees diversity not as a threat but as a source of strength that enriches national life.

This chapter examines Nigeria's diversity and explains why appreciating it is an essential step toward national unity.

#### **Nigeria: A Nation of Many Peoples**

Nigeria stretches from the mangrove forests and coastal communities of the South to the savannah and semi-arid regions of the North. Across these regions live hundreds of ethnic communities, each contributing uniquely to the country's history and development.

The three largest ethnic groups are the Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo, but there are many others, including the Edo, Ijaw, Tiv, Kanuri, Nupe, Efik, Ibibio, Urhobo, Itsekiri, Idoma, Gwari (Gbagyi), Jukun, Berom, Bachama, and numerous

smaller communities. Every ethnic group possesses its own language, customs, traditional institutions, arts, and values.

Recognising and respecting this diversity strengthens the bonds of national unity.

**Table 4.1: Examples of Nigeria's Ethnic Diversity**

Region

Examples of Ethnic Groups

North-West

Hausa, Fulani

North-East

Kanuri, Bachama, Babur

North-Central

Tiv, Idoma, Nupe, Gbagyi, Jukun

South-West

Yoruba, Awori, Ijebu, Ekiti

South-East

Igbo, Ikwerre, Ngwa

South-South

Edo, Ijaw, Urhobo, Itsekiri, Isoko, Efik, Ibibio

This table is illustrative rather than exhaustive.

## Diversity as a National Strength

Countries that successfully manage diversity often enjoy greater creativity, innovation, and resilience. Different cultures contribute different ideas, skills, and perspectives to national development.

Nigeria's diversity enriches:

Literature and languages.

Music, dance, and entertainment.

Cuisine and fashion.

Traditional governance systems.

Arts and crafts.

Entrepreneurship and commerce.

Tourism and cultural diplomacy.

Rather than dividing the nation, these differences can become powerful tools for development.

Learning from One Another

A detribalised Nigerian is curious about other cultures. Learning another Nigerian language, attending cultural festivals, tasting traditional foods, or visiting different parts of the country broadens understanding and reduces prejudice.

Simple acts such as respecting another person's greeting, dress, customs, or traditions help to build trust and mutual respect.

## Diversity and National Development

Economic growth is strengthened when people from different backgrounds collaborate. Businesses benefit from varied perspectives, educational institutions become richer through cultural exchange, and public institutions gain legitimacy when all citizens feel included.

Inclusive societies are often better equipped to:

Solve complex problems.

Attract investment.

Promote innovation.

Prevent conflict.

Strengthen democratic governance.

Nigeria's diversity should therefore be viewed as a strategic national resource.

### Figure 4.1: Diversity and National Progress

Respect for Diversity ↓ Mutual Understanding ↓ Trust and Cooperation ↓  
National Unity ↓ Economic Growth and Sustainable Development

### Overcoming Stereotypes

Many stereotypes about ethnic groups are based on hearsay rather than personal experience. Such stereotypes often ignore the fact that every community has honest, hardworking, talented, and law-abiding citizens, just as every community has individuals who act wrongly.

A detribalised Nigerian avoids making sweeping generalisations about any ethnic group. Instead, individuals are judged according to their character, conduct, and competence.

## **Practical Ways to Appreciate Diversity**

Every Nigerian can take practical steps to deepen appreciation of the country's diversity:

Learn basic greetings in at least one of her Nigerian language.

Read books about other cultures.

Visit different regions of Nigeria.

Participate in cultural festivals and national events.

Encourage children to make friends across ethnic lines.

Support inclusive workplaces and schools.

Reject jokes or comments that ridicule other ethnic groups.

These actions may appear small, but together they help to build a stronger nation.

## **Reflection Questions**

How much do I know about cultures outside my own?

Have I allowed stereotypes to influence my opinions of others?

What practical step can I take this month to learn about another Nigerian culture?

How can my workplace, school, or community celebrate diversity more effectively?

## **Chapter Summary**

Nigeria's diversity is not a weakness but a priceless national treasure. The country's many ethnic groups, languages, traditions, and cultures provide opportunities for learning, innovation, and national development. Becoming a detribalised Nigerian requires appreciating these differences, rejecting stereotypes, and embracing the belief that every Nigerian has something valuable to contribute to the nation.

National unity grows when diversity is respected, celebrated, and wisely managed.

Key Thought: "Our many cultures are like the colours of a beautiful tapestry; each is unique, but together they create the rich fabric of Nigeria."

The next chapter, Chapter Five: Step One —Changing the Mindset, begins the practical, step-by-step journey of becoming a detribalised Nigerian by addressing personal attitudes, unconscious bias, and the transformation of thought patterns.

## CHAPTER FIVE

### STEP ONE—CHANGING THE MINDSET

#### INTRODUCTION

Every lasting transformation begins in the mind. Before tribalism can be eliminated from society, it must first be removed from individual hearts and minds. Laws, government policies, and constitutional provisions can promote national integration, but they cannot by themselves change personal attitudes. Real change occurs when individuals consciously reject prejudice and embrace fairness, respect, and national unity.

The journey to becoming a detribalised Nigerian therefore begins with a change of mindset. This chapter explains how personal beliefs, attitudes, and perceptions shape our behaviour and how they can be transformed.

#### Understanding Mindset

A mindset is the collection of beliefs, assumptions, attitudes, and values that influence how we think and act. From childhood, many people unconsciously absorb opinions about other ethnic groups through family conversations, friends, schools, the media, and society.

Some of these beliefs are positive, while others become stereotypes that unfairly judge people before they are known personally.

A detribalised Nigerian deliberately examines these beliefs and rejects those that promote hatred, prejudice, or discrimination.

#### Recognising Personal Bias

Bias is a preference or prejudice that affects our judgment, often without our awareness. Ethnic bias may appear in subtle ways, such as:

Assuming that people from a particular ethnic group are more trustworthy or less trustworthy.

Preferring to employ or promote only members of one's own ethnic group.

Making jokes that ridicule other cultures.

Feeling uncomfortable working with people from different backgrounds.

Judging individuals by stereotypes instead of their character.

Recognising these biases is the first step toward overcoming them.

#### Table 5.1: From Tribal Thinking to National Thinking

Tribal Mindset

National Mindset

"My tribe first."

"Nigeria first."

Judges by ethnicity.

Judges by character and competence.

Encourages exclusion.

Promotes inclusion.

Protects narrow interests.

Advances the common good.

Creates division.

Builds unity and trust.

### **Challenging Stereotypes**

Stereotypes are oversimplified beliefs about groups of people. They often arise from rumours, isolated incidents, or historical misunderstandings.

No ethnic group possesses all the virtues or all the faults. Every community has honest and dishonest people, hardworking and lazy individuals, leaders and followers. It is therefore unfair to judge an entire group based on the actions of a few.

A detribalised Nigerian asks:

Is this belief supported by evidence?

Am I judging this person fairly?

Would I want others to judge me by a stereotype?

Such questions help to replace prejudice with understanding.

### **Developing Empathy**

Empathy is the ability to understand and appreciate the experiences and feelings of others. When we learn about the history, culture, and challenges of other Nigerian communities, we become more compassionate and less judgmental.

Empathy grows through:

Listening with respect.

Visiting other communities.

Reading about different cultures.

Building genuine friendships across ethnic lines.

Working together on shared goals.

Empathy transforms strangers into neighbours and neighbours into fellow citizens.

### **Replacing Fear with Trust**

Fear often fuels tribalism. Some people fear that accepting others will weaken their own identity or reduce opportunities for their ethnic group. In reality, societies that encourage inclusion, fairness, and merit are stronger and more prosperous.

Trust is built when people interact honestly, cooperate in solving problems, and respect one another's rights.

### **Figure 5.1: The Mindset Transformation Process**

Awareness of Bias ↓ Self-Reflection ↓ Learning and Understanding ↓ Empathy  
↓ Respect for Diversity ↓ Detribalised Thinking

Practical Steps for Mindset Change

To develop a national mindset:

Examine your own attitudes honestly.

Avoid spreading ethnic stereotypes.

Judge individuals by their conduct and competence.

Read widely about Nigeria's diverse cultures.

Encourage children to respect every Nigerian.

Correct prejudice whenever it appears in conversations.

Pray and work for national unity.

Changing the mind is a continuous process that requires humility and determination.

### **Reflection Questions**

What ethnic stereotypes did I grow up hearing?

Which of these beliefs have I personally tested?

How can I replace prejudice with understanding?

What practical action will I take this week to strengthen national unity?

### **Chapter Summary**

The first and most important step toward becoming a detribalised Nigerian is transforming one's mindset. By recognising personal biases, rejecting stereotypes, developing empathy, and embracing fairness, every Nigerian can contribute to building a nation where character, competence, and integrity matter more than ethnic origin.

National transformation begins with personal transformation. When enough citizens change their thinking, society itself begins to change.

Key Thought: "A united Nigeria begins with a renewed mind. When we change the way we think about one another, we change the future of our nation."

The next chapter, Chapter Six: Step Two —Building Cross-Cultural Friendships, will show how meaningful relationships across ethnic boundaries help break prejudice, strengthen trust, and foster a truly detribalised Nigeria.

## CHAPTER SIX

### STEP TWO—BUILDING CROSS -CULTURAL FRIENDSHIPS

#### INTRODUCTION

One of the most effective ways to overcome tribalism is through genuine friendship. Prejudice often flourishes where there is little interaction, while understanding grows through meaningful personal relationships. When Nigerians from different ethnic backgrounds live, work, study, worship, and celebrate together, they discover that they have far more in common than what separates them.

A detribalised Nigerian deliberately builds bridges across ethnic, regional, and religious boundaries. Friendship is therefore not merely a social activity; it is an instrument of nation -building.

#### Why Cross-Cultural Friendships Matter

Friendship creates opportunities to understand different ways of life. It allows people to appreciate other cultures directly instead of relying on rumours or stereotypes.

Cross-cultural friendships:

Reduce prejudice and fear.

Promote mutual respect .

Build trust across communities.

Encourage cooperation in workplaces and schools.

Strengthen national unity.

Create lifelong personal and professional networks.

Many Nigerians who have studied, worked, or served in states outside their place of origin testify that such experiences transformed their attitudes towards other ethnic groups.

#### Breaking the Walls of Suspicion

Suspicion is often rooted in ignorance. When individuals avoid interacting with people from different backgrounds, stereotypes remain unchallenged.

Building friendships requires openness and humility. It involves:

Starting conversations with people from different ethnic groups.

Participating in community activities.

Working together on common projects.

Visiting one another during cultural and religious celebrations.

Showing genuine interest in learning about other traditions.

These simple acts gradually replace suspicion with confidence and trust.

#### Table 6.1: The Benefits of Cross -Cultural Friendships

Friendship Across Ethnic Groups

National Benefit

Greater understanding

Stronger national unity

Mutual respect

Reduced prejudice

Exchange of ideas

Innovation and creativity

Wider professional networks

Economic opportunities

Peaceful coexistence

National stability

### **Learning Through Shared Experiences**

Friendships become stronger when people share experiences. Working together in schools, businesses, neighbourhood associations, youth organisations, and professional bodies helps people appreciate each other's strengths.

National programmes that bring young Nigerians together also provide opportunities for lasting friendships that transcend ethnic differences.

Every interaction becomes an opportunity to promote unity.

### **Respecting Cultural Differences**

True friendship does not require uniformity. Friends may speak different languages, eat different foods, observe different customs, or practise different religions. Respecting these differences enriches relationships rather than weakening them.

A detribalised Nigerian:

Respects cultural practices that are consistent with human dignity.

Learns from other traditions.

Avoids mocking unfamiliar customs.

Appreciates cultural diversity as part of Nigeria's national heritage.

Respect builds lasting friendship.

### **The Role of Families**

Parents and guardians play a crucial role in shaping children's attitudes towards other ethnic groups.

Families should:

Avoid making derogatory remarks about other tribes.

Encourage children to make friends from different backgrounds.

Welcome visitors from all parts of Nigeria.

Teach respect for every Nigerian regardless of ethnicity.

Children who grow up in inclusive environments are more likely to become detribalised adults.

### **The Workplace as a Centre of Unity**

Modern workplaces often bring together Nigerians from many ethnic backgrounds. Organisations that promote fairness, teamwork, and equal opportunity create environments where friendships naturally develop.

Leaders should encourage:

Inclusive teamwork.

Merit-based appointments.

Respectful communication.

Zero tolerance for ethnic discrimination .

Equal opportunities for professional growth.

Healthy workplaces contribute to national integration.

### **Figure 6.1: Friendship Builds National Unity**

Interaction ↓ Understanding ↓ Trust ↓ Cooperation ↓ National Unity ↓ Peace and Development

#### **Practical Steps**

You can begin building cross -cultural friendships by:

Introducing yourself to someone from another ethnic group.

Learning basic greetings in another Nigerian language.

Visiting cultural festivals outside your own community.

Reading books about other Nigerian cultures.

Participating in community service projects with diverse groups.

Celebrating national events together rather than emphasizing differences.

Small actions, consistently practised, create lasting change.

#### **Reflection Questions**

How many close friends do I have from ethnic groups different from my own?

Have my friendships challenged any stereotypes I previously held?

What practical step can I take this month to build a new cross -cultural friendship?

How can I encourage my family and colleagues to value diversity?

### **Chapter Summary**

Cross-cultural friendships are among the strongest foundations for national unity. They replace fear with trust, prejudice with understanding, and division with cooperation. Every friendship that crosses ethnic boundaries weakens tribalism and strengthens Nigeria.

Becoming a detribalised Nigerian requires intentional effort to build relationships based on respect, fairness, and shared citizenship. Through these relationships, Nigerians can discover that their common hopes and aspirations are far greater than their differences.

Key Thought: "Every genuine friendship across ethnic lines is a bridge that strengthens the unity of Nigeria."

In Chapter Seven: Step Three —Learning Other Nigerian Languages, we will explore how language promotes understanding, reduces prejudice, and deepens national integration, while providing practical ways to acquire basic communication skills in other Nigerian languages.

CHAPTER SEVEN

STEP THREE —LEARNING OTHER NIGERIAN LANGUAGES

INTRODUCTION

Language is one of the strongest expressions of culture and identity. It preserves history, transmits values, and strengthens relationships within communities. Nigeria is blessed with over 500 indigenous languages, making it one of the most linguistically diverse countries in the world.

While Nigerians have every reason to cherish their mother tongues, learning the language of another ethnic group can promote understanding, friendship, and national unity. Even learning simple greetings and everyday expressions demonstrates respect and goodwill.

A detribalised Nigerian recognizes that language should unite rather than divide.

The Importance of Language

Language is more than a means of communication. It reflects the history, customs, beliefs, and worldview of a people.

When we make the effort to speak another person's language, even imperfectly, we communicate respect and openness. Such gestures often break down barriers that years of suspicion have built.

Language therefore serves as a bridge between cultures.

Nigeria's Linguistic Wealth

Nigeria's many languages represent an invaluable national heritage. Every language carries unique traditions, literature, songs, proverbs, and indigenous knowledge.

While major languages such as Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo are widely spoken, many other Nigerian languages make equally important contributions to the nation's cultural richness.

Protecting these languages while encouraging mutual understanding strengthens national identity.

Table 7.1: Benefits of Learning Other Nigerian Languages

| Benefit                          |
|----------------------------------|
| National Impact                  |
| Better communication             |
| Stronger relationships           |
| Greater cultural understanding   |
| Reduced prejudice                |
| Increased business opportunities |
| Economic growth                  |
| Enhanced national integration    |
| Peaceful coexistence             |
| Respect for diversity            |
| National unity                   |

## Language and National Unity

Many misunderstandings arise simply because people cannot communicate effectively.

Learning another Nigerian language :

Promotes friendship.

Encourages cultural appreciation.

Facilitates business and trade.

Improves collaboration in workplaces.

Builds confidence when travelling.

Strengthens national integration.

A few words spoken with sincerity often open doors that prejudice keeps closed.

## Practical Ways to Learn

Learning another Nigerian language need not be difficult.

You can begin by:

Learning common greetings.

Listening to radio and television programmes.

Watching Nigerian films in other languages.

Reading children's books and simple texts.

Practising with friends and colleagues.

Using language -learning applications where available.

Visiting communities where the language is spoken.

Consistency is more important than perfection.

## Respecting Every Language

No Nigerian language is superior to another. Every language reflects the dignity and identity of the people who speak it.

A detribalised Nigerian:

Avoids mocking another person's accent.

Respects minority languages.

Encourages multilingualism.

Appreciates linguistic diversity.

Promotes mutual understanding through communication.

Respect for language is respect for people.

## Figure 7.1: Language as a Bridge

Learning a Language ↓ Better Communication ↓ Mutual Understanding ↓ Trust and Friendship ↓ National Unity

## The Role of Schools and Families

Parents should encourage children to value both their mother tongue and other Nigerian languages. Schools can strengthen national integration by promoting language clubs, cultural exchange programmes, debates, drama, and inter-school competitions involving different languages and cultures.

Educational institutions play a vital role in producing citizens who appreciate Nigeria's diversity.

### **Language in Public Service**

Public servants who understand more than one Nigerian language are often better equipped to serve diverse communities. Effective communication improves service delivery, conflict resolution, public enlightenment, and community participation.

Government agencies should encourage language training where appropriate, especially for officers serving outside their states of origin.

### **Reflection Questions**

How many Nigerian languages can I speak or understand?

Have I ever tried to learn basic greetings in another Nigerian language?

What language would I like to begin learning, and why?

How can language learning help strengthen national unity?

### **Practical Exercise**

Choose one Nigerian language other than your own. Over the next four weeks, learn at least twenty commonly used words and expressions. Use them respectfully whenever you interact with speakers of that language. Record how this experience changes your perception and strengthens your relationships.

### **Chapter Summary**

Language is one of the most powerful instruments of national integration. Learning another Nigerian language demonstrates respect, promotes communication, reduces prejudice, and builds lasting friendships. Becoming a

detribalised Nigerian includes a willingness to communicate across cultural boundaries and to value every language as part of Nigeria's rich national heritage.

Every new word learned is another step toward understanding a fellow Nigerian.

Key Thought: "When we learn one another's language, we begin to understand one another's hearts."

The next chapter, Chapter Eight: Step Four—Rejecting Nepotism and Favouritism, will examine how merit, fairness, and ethical leadership can replace ethnic patronage in public and private institutions, thereby strengthening governance and national development.

## CHAPTER EIGHT

### STEP FOUR—REJECTING NEPOTISM AND FAVOURITISM

#### INTRODUCTION

One of the greatest obstacles to national development is the practice of giving preference to family members, friends, or people from one's ethnic group instead of selecting the most qualified and deserving individuals. This practice, commonly known as nepotism and favouritism, weakens institutions, discourages excellence, and undermines public confidence.

A detribalised Nigerian believes that every citizen deserves equal opportunity and that appointments, promotions, admissions, scholarships, and contracts should be based primarily on competence, integrity, and merit.

Rejecting nepotism is not only a moral duty; it is a patriotic responsibility that strengthens national unity and accelerates development.

#### Understanding Nepotism and Favouritism

Nepotism is the practice of giving unfair advantage to relatives or close associates because of personal relationships rather than merit.

Favouritism is broader. It includes unfair preference based on ethnicity, religion, political affiliation, friendship, or other personal connections.

Both practices violate the principles of justice, fairness, and equal opportunity.

#### How Nepotism Harms Nigeria

When merit is ignored, institutions become weaker.

The consequences include:

Recruitment of less qualified personnel.

Reduced productivity.

Declining public confidence.

Low staff morale.

Corruption and abuse of office.

Poor service delivery.

Slower national development.

Citizens lose faith in public institutions when they believe opportunities are determined by connections rather than competence.

#### Table 8.1: Merit versus Nepotism

Merit-Based System

Nepotism-Based System

Competence determines selection

Personal connections determine selection

Encourages excellence

Discourages hard work

Builds strong institutions

Weakens institutions

Promotes fairness

Creates resentment

Supports national unity

Deepens division

Meritocracy as a National Value

Meritocracy means rewarding ability, integrity, hard work, and performance. It does not exclude fairness or inclusion; rather, it ensures that opportunities are open to all and that the best -qualified individuals are selected through transparent processes.

A merit-based society:

Encourages innovation.

Rewards excellence.

Attracts investment.

Improves public services.

Strengthens economic growth.

Builds trust among citizens.

Merit benefits every ethnic group because it allows talent to flourish wherever it is found.

## Ethical Leadership

Leaders set the tone for institutions. Ethical leaders resist pressure to favour relatives, friends, or members of their ethnic group. Instead, they uphold fairness, transparency, and accountability.

An ethical leader:

Makes decisions objectively.

Applies rules consistently.

Declares conflicts of interest.

Rewards performance.

Protects the rights of all citizens.

Leadership by example inspires others to act fairly.

## Figure 8.1: The Cycle of Merit -Based Development

Fair Recruitment ↓ Competent Workforce ↓ Efficient Institutions ↓ Public Trust  
↓ National Development

The Responsibility of Every Citizen

Rejecting nepotism is not the responsibility of leaders alone. Every Nigerian has a role to play.

Individuals can:

Recommend qualified people instead of merely familiar people.

Oppose discrimination in workplaces and communities.

Encourage transparent recruitment processes.

Celebrate excellence wherever it is found.

Avoid seeking unfair advantage through ethnic or family connections.

Personal integrity strengthens national integrity.

Balancing Compassion and Fairness

Helping family members or members of one's community is a valued cultural tradition. However, compassion should never lead to injustice. Supporting relatives through guidance, education, mentoring, or financial assistance is commendable, but denying qualified others equal opportunity is unfair and harmful to society.

A detribalised Nigerian distinguishes between kindness and favouritism.

Reflection Questions

Have I ever supported someone solely because of family or ethnic ties instead of merit?

How can I promote fairness in my workplace or community?

What qualities should guide my decisions when recommending people for opportunities?

How does merit contribute to national development?

### **Practical Exercise**

During the next month, consciously evaluate people by their competence, integrity, and performance rather than by personal relationships or ethnic background. Reflect on how this practice influences your decisions and interactions.

### **Chapter Summary**

Nepotism and favouritism weaken institutions, discourage excellence, and divide society. A detribalised Nigerian rejects these practices and supports merit, fairness, transparency, and equal opportunity for all citizens. Nations prosper when talent is recognised, integrity is rewarded, and justice is applied without bias.

Replacing favouritism with merit is one of the surest paths to building a stronger, more united, and more prosperous Nigeria.

Key Thought: "When merit becomes the standard, every Nigerian has a fair opportunity to contribute to national progress."

Chapter Nine: Step Five—Practising Inclusive Citizenship will explore the rights and responsibilities of every Nigerian, emphasizing civic participation, respect for the rule of law, community service, and active commitment to building an inclusive nation.

## CHAPTER NINE

### STEP FIVE—PRACTISING INCLUSIVE CITIZENSHIP

#### INTRODUCTION

Citizenship is more than possessing a passport or being born within a country's borders. It involves rights, responsibilities, and active participation in building the nation. A detribalised Nigerian recognizes that every citizen, irrespective of ethnic origin, religion, gender, or region, deserves equal dignity, justice, and opportunity.

Inclusive citizenship means ensuring that no Nigerian feels excluded from the political, economic, or social life of the country. It encourages every citizen to contribute positively to national development while respecting the rights of others.

This chapter explains how practising inclusive citizenship strengthens national unity and accelerates sustainable development.

#### Understanding Citizenship

A citizen is a person who belongs to a nation and enjoys the protection of its laws while accepting the responsibilities that accompany membership.

#### Good citizenship requires:

Respect for the Constitution and the rule of law.

Obedience to lawful authority.

Respect for the rights of others.

Payment of taxes and lawful civic obligations.

Participation in elections and public affairs.

Commitment to peace, justice, and national development.

Citizenship is therefore both a privilege and a responsibility.

#### The Meaning of Inclusive Citizenship

Inclusive citizenship ensures that every Nigerian has a sense of belonging, regardless of ethnic or religious background. It rejects discrimination and promotes equal access to opportunities.

An inclusive citizen:

Treats every Nigerian with respect.

Supports equal opportunities for all.

Rejects discrimination and hate speech.

Protects the rights of minorities.

Promotes dialogue instead of conflict.

Places national interest above sectional interests.

Such attitudes strengthen democracy and social harmony.

#### Table 9.1: Inclusive Citizenship in Practice

Inclusive Behaviour

National Benefit

Respecting all citizens

National unity

Participating in elections

Stronger democracy

Obedying the law

Social order

Community service

Local development

Rejecting discrimination

Peaceful coexistence

Supporting equal opportunity

Justice and fairness

Civic Participation

A detribalised Nigerian does not remain indifferent to national issues. Civic participation means taking an active role in improving society through lawful and constructive means.

Examples include:

Voting responsibly during elections.

Attending community meetings.

Joining professional and voluntary organisations.

Participating in environmental sanitation.

Supporting educational and health initiatives.

Promoting peace during elections and public debates.

Active citizens strengthen democratic governance.

## **Respect for the Rule of Law**

The rule of law means that everyone, regardless of status or ethnicity, is subject to the same laws.

Respecting the rule of law requires:

Rejecting violence.

Settling disputes peacefully.

Respecting court decisions.

Reporting crime.

Protecting public property.

Opposing corruption.

Where the rule of law prevails, citizens develop confidence in public institutions.

## **Community Service**

Nation-building begins within local communities. Every Nigerian can contribute through voluntary service, mentoring young people, supporting schools, assisting vulnerable groups, planting trees, promoting environmental cleanliness, or participating in local development projects.

Community service strengthens social responsibility and builds trust across ethnic boundaries.

### **Figure 9.1: Inclusive Citizenship and National Development**

Responsible Citizens ↓ Active Civic Participation ↓ Strong Communities ↓  
National Unity ↓ Sustainable Development

### **Respecting Differences**

Inclusive citizenship does not require everyone to think alike. Nigerians may differ in culture, language, religion, or political opinion while remaining united in their commitment to peace, justice, and national progress.

Respectful disagreement is healthier than hatred or intolerance.

Listening to differing viewpoints promotes better decision-making and strengthens democracy.

### **Building a Culture of Inclusion**

Government, educational institutions, religious organisations, businesses, families, and the media all have responsibilities in promoting inclusive citizenship.

### **They should:**

Encourage equal opportunity.

Celebrate cultural diversity.

Discourage hate speech.

Promote civic education.

Recognise excellence regardless of ethnic origin.

Foster dialogue and reconciliation where conflicts arise.

A culture of inclusion benefits everyone.

### **Reflection Questions**

What responsibilities do I owe my country as a citizen?

How can I become more actively involved in community development?

Have I treated every Nigerian with equal respect?

What practical action can I take this month to promote inclusion?

### **Practical Exercise**

Identify one community project or voluntary activity in which you can participate during the next four weeks. Work alongside people from different ethnic backgrounds and reflect on how the experience strengthens your appreciation of national unity.

### **Chapter Summary**

Inclusive citizenship is the practical expression of patriotism. It requires active participation in national life, respect for the rule of law, community service, and equal treatment of all citizens. A detribalised Nigerian understands that national unity is built not only by government policies but also by the daily actions of responsible citizens.

When every Nigerian feels included, respected, and valued, the nation becomes stronger, more peaceful, and better equipped to achieve sustainable development.

Key Thought: "The strength of Nigeria lies not in the diversity of its people alone, but in their willingness to stand together as equal citizens with one common destiny."

The next chapter, Chapter Ten: Step Six —Using Education to Fight Tribalism, will examine how schools, universities, families, and civic education can shape a new generation of Nigerians who value merit, tolerance, unity, and national service.

## **CHAPTER TEN**

### **STEP SIX—USING EDUCATION TO FIGHT TRIBALISM**

#### **INTRODUCTION**

Education is one of the most powerful instruments for transforming society. It shapes attitudes, develops critical thinking, builds character, and prepares citizens for responsible leadership. While laws can prohibit discrimination, education changes hearts and minds by teaching values such as justice, tolerance, mutual respect, and national unity.

A detribalised Nigerian is not born but made through continuous learning and positive socialization. Families, schools, religious institutions, universities, and the media all have important roles in nurturing citizens who value competence above ethnicity and patriotism above sectional interests.

This chapter examines how education can become a powerful weapon against tribalism.

#### **Education Beyond Literacy**

Education is more than learning to read and write. It is the development of knowledge, skills, attitudes, and values that enable individuals to contribute positively to society.

A sound education teaches:

Respect for human dignity.

Honesty and integrity.

Civic responsibility.

Critical thinking.

Peaceful conflict resolution.

Appreciation of cultural diversity.

National loyalty.

When these values are properly taught, tribal prejudice gradually gives way to mutual understanding.

### The Role of the Family

The first classroom is the home. Children often learn attitudes toward other ethnic groups from parents and relatives before they enter school.

Parents should:

Speak respectfully about all ethnic groups.

Discourage ethnic stereotypes.

Encourage friendships across cultural boundaries.

Teach fairness and kindness.

Celebrate Nigeria's diversity.

Children raised in homes that promote inclusion are more likely to become detribalised adults.

### The Role of Schools

Schools provide opportunities for children from different backgrounds to learn together. They should intentionally promote national integration through:

Civic education.

Nigerian history.

Cultural exchange activities.

Debate and essay competitions.

Sports and teamwork.

Language clubs.

Leadership training.

Teachers should serve as role models by treating every student fairly and encouraging mutual respect.

### Table 10.1: Educational Institutions and National Unity

Institution

Contribution

Family

Builds values and attitudes

Primary School

Teaches respect and cooperation

Secondary School

Promotes civic responsibility

University

Encourages diversity and critical thinking

Professional Institutions

Strengthen ethical leadership

Adult Education

Promotes lifelong learning and national consciousness

Civic Education

Civic education equips citizens with knowledge of their rights, responsibilities, and democratic values.

An effective civic education programme teaches:

The Constitution.

Human rights.

Rule of law.

Good governance.

Electoral responsibility.

National symbols.

Peacebuilding.

Responsible citizenship.

Citizens who understand these principles are less likely to be manipulated through ethnic or sectional politics.

## Learning Through National Programmes

Programmes that bring Nigerians together from different parts of the country help break down prejudice and build lasting friendships.

Student exchanges, inter-school competitions, volunteer programmes, professional conferences, youth leadership camps, and national service initiatives expose participants to different cultures and broaden their understanding of Nigeria.

Such experiences help replace stereotypes with genuine appreciation.

### Figure 10.1: Education for National Unity

Education ↓ Knowledge ↓ Understanding ↓ Tolerance ↓ National Unity ↓ Sustainable Development

Higher Education and Research

Universities and research institutions should encourage studies on peacebuilding, conflict resolution, governance, ethics, leadership, and national integration.

Academic research can provide evidence-based solutions to ethnic tensions and contribute to better public policies.

Scholars also have a responsibility to promote objective scholarship free from ethnic bias.

### Lifelong Learning

Education does not end with graduation. Every Nigerian should continue learning through books, seminars, workshops, documentaries, travel, and interaction with people from different backgrounds.

Continuous learning broadens perspectives and reduces prejudice.

A detribalised Nigerian remains open to new ideas throughout life.

### **Reflection Questions**

What lessons about other ethnic groups did I learn while growing up?

Have my educational experiences reduced or reinforced tribal prejudice?

How can schools in Nigeria do more to promote national unity?

What new knowledge can I acquire to become a better citizen?

### **Practical Exercise**

Read a book or watch a documentary about a Nigerian ethnic group other than your own. Discuss what you have learned with family members, colleagues, or students, and identify at least three positive values you admire from that culture.

### **Chapter Summary**

Education is one of the most effective tools for overcoming tribalism. Families, schools, universities, and civic institutions all have vital roles in shaping citizens who value fairness, diversity, and national unity. Through education, prejudice can be replaced with understanding, stereotypes with knowledge, and division with cooperation.

A well-educated mind recognizes that Nigeria's diversity is not a barrier to progress but a foundation for building a peaceful, united, and prosperous nation. Key Thought: "Education enlightens the mind, transforms the heart, and builds the united nation that every Nigerian desires."

The next chapter, Chapter Eleven: Step Seven —Responsible Politics, will examine how Nigerians can move beyond ethnic politics by voting based on competence, integrity, policies, and accountability rather than tribal or sectional loyalties.

## **CHAPTER ELEVEN**

### **STEP SEVEN—RESPONSIBLE POLITICS**

#### **INTRODUCTION**

Politics is one of the most powerful instruments for shaping the future of a nation. When practised responsibly, it promotes justice, development, security, and national unity. When driven by tribalism, hatred, and selfish interests, it divides society, weakens democratic institutions, and slows national progress.

Nigeria's political history has demonstrated both the promise and the dangers of politics. Too often, elections have been influenced by ethnic, religious, and regional loyalties rather than by competence, integrity, and sound public policies. A detribalised Nigerian understands that good governance depends on electing leaders who are capable, accountable, and committed to serving the entire nation.

This chapter examines how responsible politics can help build a united and prosperous Nigeria.

#### **Politics Should Be About Service**

The primary purpose of politics is public service. Leadership is a trust that should be exercised for the welfare of all citizens, not merely for the benefit of one ethnic group, political party, or personal network.

Responsible political leaders:

Place national interest above personal ambition.

Respect the Constitution and the rule of law.

- Protect the rights of all citizens.
- Promote justice and equal opportunity.
- Use public resources responsibly.
- Encourage peace and national unity.
- Politics should unite the nation rather than divide it.
- Voting Beyond Ethnicity
- One of the most important responsibilities of citizens in a democracy is choosing their leaders wisely.
- A detribalised Nigerian asks important questions before voting:
  - Does this candidate possess integrity?
  - Is the candidate competent?
  - What policies are being proposed?
  - Does the candidate have a record of public service?
  - Will this person govern fairly for every Nigerian?
- Voting based on competence rather than ethnicity strengthens democracy and improves governance.

**Table 11.1: Ethnic Politics versus Responsible Politics**

Ethnic Politics

Responsible Politics

Tribe before nation

- Nation before tribe
- Personality-centred
- Policy-centred
- Division
- Unity
- Patronage
- Merit
- Short-term gains
- Long-term development
- Conflict
- Cooperation
- Accountability in Leadership
- Democracy does not end after elections. Citizens have a continuing responsibility to monitor government performance.
- Responsible citizenship requires:
  - Asking informed questions.
  - Demanding transparency.
  - Opposing corruption.
  - Supporting lawful civic engagement.

Evaluating leaders based on results rather than ethnic identity.

Good governance flourishes when leaders know they will be held accountable.

Rejecting Hate Speech

Political competition should never become an excuse for promoting hatred or violence.

Responsible political participation requires:

Respecting differing opinions.

Rejecting false information.

Avoiding inflammatory language.

Encouraging peaceful campaigns.

Accepting legitimate election outcomes while using lawful means to challenge disputes where necessary.

Political disagreements should never destroy national unity.

### Figure 11.1: Responsible Politics and National Development

Responsible Voting ↓ Competent Leadership ↓ Good Governance ↓ Public Trust  
↓ National Unity ↓ Sustainable Development

### The Role of Political Parties

Political parties should serve as schools of democracy by promoting internal democracy, issue-based campaigns, and leadership development.

Strong political parties:

Encourage debate on public policy.

Recruit competent candidates.

Promote inclusion.

Respect democratic rules .

Discourage ethnic mobilisation.

Healthy political parties contribute to national stability.

The Responsibility of Young People

Nigeria's youth constitute a significant proportion of the population. Their participation is essential for democratic renewal.

Young people should:

Register and vote.

Participate peacefully in politics.

Reject political violence.

Develop leadership skills.

Hold leaders accountable.

Promote unity through constructive engagement.

The future of Nigerian democracy depends greatly on informed and responsible young citizens.

### Reflection Questions

What qualities do I consider most important when choosing political leaders?

Have I ever allowed ethnic identity to influence my political decisions?

How can I contribute to more issue -based politics in my community?

What role should citizens play between elections?

### **Practical Exercise**

Before the next election, prepare a simple checklist for evaluating candidates. Include criteria such as integrity, competence, experience, vision, respect for the rule of law, and commitment to national unity. Use this checklist to assess candidates objectively rather than emotionally.

### **Chapter Summary**

Responsible politics is essential for building a detribalised Nigeria. Citizens must judge leaders by competence, integrity, vision, and commitment to public service rather than by ethnic or regional identity. Political leaders must govern fairly, while citizens must remain active, informed, and vigilant throughout the democratic process.

A nation prospers when politics becomes a platform for service, accountability, and national development instead of division and ethnic rivalry.

Key Thought: "The ballot should be guided by conscience, competence, and character—not by tribe or ethnicity."

The next chapter, Chapter Twelve: Step Eight—Media, Social Media, and Tribal Narratives, will examine how traditional and digital media can either deepen ethnic divisions or become powerful tools for promoting national unity, responsible communication, and peace -building.

## **CHAPTER TWELVE**

### **STEP EIGHT—MEDIA, SOCIAL MEDIA, AND TRIBAL NARRATIVES**

#### **INTRODUCTION**

The media plays a powerful role in shaping public opinion, influencing attitudes, and promoting national values. Newspapers, radio, television, online platforms, and social media have transformed the way Nigerians receive and share information. Used responsibly, they educate, unite, and inspire citizens. Used irresponsibly, they spread misinformation, deepen ethnic divisions, and fuel conflict.

A detribalised Nigerian understands that every message shared has consequences. Words can either build bridges of understanding or erect walls of suspicion. Responsible communication is therefore an essential step towards national unity.

This chapter examines how traditional and social media can become instruments for promoting peace, tolerance, and responsible citizenship.

#### **The Power of the Media**

The media is often described as the "Fourth Estate" because of its influence on governance and society. It informs citizens, exposes wrongdoing, encourages public debate, and promotes accountability.

When reporting is fair, balanced, and factual, the media:

Strengthens democracy.

Promotes transparency.

Encourages national dialogue.

Educates the public.

Supports peaceful coexistence.

However, biased or inflammatory reporting can produce the opposite effect.

### Social Media: Opportunity and Responsibility

Social media has given every citizen the opportunity to become both a consumer and a publisher of information. Messages now travel across Nigeria within seconds.

This creates enormous opportunities for:

Civic education.

Business development.

Cultural exchange.

Youth engagement.

National conversations.

At the same time, it increases the risk of:

False information.

Hate speech.

Ethnic stereotyping.

Rumour-mongering.

Online harassment.

Manipulation during elections.

Responsible use of social media is therefore a civic obligation.

### Table 12.1: Responsible versus Irresponsible Media Use

Responsible Communication

Irresponsible Communication

Verifies facts

Spreads rumours

Promotes unity

Promotes division

Respects all communities

Uses hate speech

Encourages dialogue

Encourages hostility

Educates the public

Misleads the public

Recognising Misinformation

Not every message received on social media is true. Before forwarding information, responsible citizens should ask:

Is the information from a credible source?

Can it be independently verified?

Does it promote peace or provoke hatred?

Would I share this if it concerned my own community?

Could this message harm innocent people?

Taking a few moments to verify information can prevent misunderstanding and conflict.

### Rejecting Hate Speech

Hate speech includes expressions that insult, threaten, or encourage hostility against individuals or groups because of their ethnicity, religion, or other characteristics.

A detribalised Nigerian refuses to:

Share ethnic insults.

Circulate false accusations.

Encourage violence.

Mock another ethnic group.

Celebrate the suffering of any community.

Respectful disagreement is compatible with democracy; hate speech is not.

### Figure 12.1: Responsible Communication

Verify Information ↓ Think Before Sharing ↓ Promote Respect ↓ Build Public Trust ↓ Strengthen National Unity

Promoting Positive Narratives

The media should highlight stories that unite Nigerians, including:

Successful inter-ethnic cooperation.

Outstanding achievements by Nigerians from all backgrounds.

Peacebuilding initiatives.

Community development projects.

Youth leadership.

Acts of compassion and national service.

Positive stories inspire hope and strengthen national identity.

### The Role of Journalists and Content Creators

Journalists, broadcasters, bloggers, influencers, and content creators have significant influence over public opinion.

### They should:

Report accurately and fairly.

Avoid sensationalism.

Protect human dignity.

Promote ethical journalism.

Encourage constructive public dialogue.

Give balanced coverage to national issues.

Professional ethics remain essential in both traditional and digital media.

## Reflection Questions

Do I verify information before sharing it?

Have I ever unknowingly shared false or divisive content?

How can I use my social media accounts to promote national unity?

What responsibility do journalists and citizens share in building peace?

## Practical Exercise

During the next month, make a commitment to verify every important message before forwarding it. In addition, intentionally share at least one positive story each week that celebrates unity, cooperation, or achievement by Nigerians from different ethnic backgrounds.

## Chapter Summary

The media has enormous power to influence national attitudes. Responsible communication promotes truth, trust, peace, and unity, while misinformation and hate speech deepen division and conflict. Every Nigerian has a responsibility to communicate ethically, verify facts, reject prejudice, and use both traditional and social media to strengthen national cohesion.

A detribalised Nigerian understands that every word spoken, written, or shared should contribute to building a more united and peaceful nation.

Key Thought: "Words have the power to divide a nation or to unite it. Choose words that build bridges, not barriers."

The next chapter, Chapter Thirteen: Step Nine —Religious Institutions as Agents of National Unity, will examine how churches, mosques, and other faith communities can promote tolerance, peaceful coexistence, ethical leadership, and a shared commitment to Nigeria's unity and development.

## CHAPTER FOURTEEN

### STEP TEN—LEADERSHIP BY PERSONAL EXAMPLE

## INTRODUCTION

Leadership is not determined solely by position, wealth, age, or political office. Every Nigerian is a leader in one way or another —within the family, workplace, school, religious institution, business, or community. The most enduring form of leadership is leadership by personal example.

A detribalised Nigerian understands that lasting national transformation begins with individual conduct. People are more likely to imitate what they see than what they are merely told. Therefore, every citizen has the opportunity to influence others by living according to the values of fairness, integrity, justice, patriotism, and respect for diversity.

This chapter explains how exemplary leadership can help build a detribalised Nigeria.

## The Meaning of Leadership by Example

Leadership by example means demonstrating through one's daily actions the values one expects others to embrace.

An exemplary leader:

Acts with integrity.

Keeps promises.

Treats everyone fairly.

Rejects discrimination.

Respects the dignity of every person.

Places national interest above personal or ethnic interests.

Serves others with humility.

People trust leaders whose actions are consistent with their words.

### Character Before Position

History has shown that great leaders are remembered more for their character than for the offices they occupied.

Character includes:

Honesty.

Courage.

Humility.

Self-discipline.

Compassion.

Accountability.

Respect for others.

Without character, leadership becomes self-serving. With character, leadership becomes a force for national transformation.

### Table 14.1: Leadership by Example

#### Positive Leadership Behaviour

#### Positive National Impact

Integrity

Public trust

Fairness

National unity

Respect for diversity

Peaceful coexistence

Accountability

Good governance

Service to others

Sustainable development

Merit-based decisions

Strong institutions

#### Leading in the Family

Families are the foundation of every nation. Parents and guardians influence children's attitudes towards other ethnic groups through their words and behaviour.

Responsible parents should:

Teach respect for every Nigerian.

Avoid tribal stereotypes.

Encourage friendships across cultures.

Reward honesty and fairness.

Demonstrate kindness to all visitors regardless of ethnicity.

Children often imitate what they observe at home.

Leading in the Workplace

Every workplace offers opportunities to demonstrate detribalised leadership.

Employers and employees should:

Treat colleagues equally.

Support merit-based promotion.

Resolve disagreements professionally.

Encourage teamwork across ethnic lines.

Celebrate excellence without bias.

Inclusive workplaces strengthen productivity and national cohesion.

Leading in the Community

Community leaders, youth leaders, traditional rulers, religious leaders, teachers, and professionals all influence public attitudes.

They should:

Promote peaceful dialogue.

Resolve disputes fairly.

Encourage volunteerism.

Protect the vulnerable.

Oppose discrimination.

Inspire cooperation among diverse groups.

Strong communities become the building blocks of a strong nation.

### **Figure 14.1: Leadership by Example**

Personal Integrity ↓ Public Confidence ↓ Responsible Citizenship ↓ National Unity ↓ Peace and Sustainable Development

Everyday Acts of Leadership

Leadership is expressed through simple daily actions.

Examples include:

Greeting neighbours respectfully.

Speaking positively about other ethnic groups.

Defending victims of discrimination.

Keeping public spaces clean.

Obeying the law.

Paying lawful civic obligations.

Volunteering for community service.

Encouraging peaceful dialogue during disagreements.

Small acts performed consistently have a powerful influence on society.

Becoming an Ambassador of National Unity

Every detribalised Nigerian should become an ambassador of unity by:

Promoting fairness wherever decisions are made.

Speaking against tribal prejudice.

Encouraging inter-ethnic cooperation.

Supporting peaceful elections.

Mentoring younger Nigerians.

Demonstrating patriotism through honest service.

National transformation occurs when millions of citizens embrace these responsibilities.

### **Reflection Questions**

What example am I setting for my family, colleagues, and community?

Do my actions consistently reflect fairness and integrity?

How can I become a stronger ambassador for national unity?

Which leadership quality do I need to develop further?

### **Practical Exercise**

For the next thirty days, intentionally perform one act each day that promotes national unity, fairness, or kindness toward someone from a different ethnic or cultural background. Keep a journal of your experiences and reflect on the changes in your own attitudes and those of others.

## **Chapter Summary**

Leadership by personal example is the final practical step in becoming a detribalised Nigerian. Every citizen has the capacity to influence others through integrity, fairness, service, and respect for diversity. When individuals consistently demonstrate these values in their families, workplaces, communities, and public life, they inspire a culture of unity and responsible citizenship.

Nigeria's future depends not only on great leaders in high office but also on millions of ordinary citizens who choose to lead extraordinary lives of honesty, justice, and patriotism.

Key Thought: "The most powerful message for national unity is not spoken with words but demonstrated through daily actions."

With this chapter, the ten-step practical framework is complete. The remaining chapters can broaden the perspective by examining international lessons, a national vision, a personal action plan, and a concluding National Renewal Charter, providing a strong and inspiring conclusion to the book.

## CHAPTER FIFTEEN

### LESSONS FROM OTHER MULTI -ETHNIC COUNTRIES

#### INTRODUCTION

Nigeria is not the only country blessed with ethnic, cultural, linguistic, and religious diversity. Around the world, many nations have faced similar challenges of managing differences while building national unity. Some have struggled with ethnic conflicts, while others have developed institutions and national values that have enabled diverse populations to live and work together peacefully.

No country is perfect, and no country's experience can be copied wholesale. However, Nigeria can learn valuable lessons from the successes and failures of other multi-ethnic societies. The goal is not to imitate another nation but to adapt useful ideas to Nigeria's history, Constitution, culture, and democratic aspirations.

This chapter highlights practical lessons that can strengthen Nigeria's journey towards becoming a truly united and detribalised nation.

#### **Lesson One: Build a Strong National Identity**

Successful multi-ethnic countries encourage citizens to see themselves first as members of one nation while remaining proud of their cultural heritage.

National symbols, civic education, public institutions, and shared national values help citizens develop a common identity that transcends ethnic differences.

For Nigeria, this means promoting the belief that every citizen belongs equally to the nation and has both rights and responsibilities.

#### **Lesson Two: Merit Must Be Protected**

Many successful nations have built strong public institutions by emphasizing competence, integrity, transparency, and accountability.

Appointments into public service are increasingly based on qualifications, experience, and performance rather than ethnic or family connections.

Nigeria's development will accelerate when merit becomes the guiding principle in recruitment, promotion, leadership selection, and public service delivery.

#### **Table 15.1: Lessons for Nigeria**

International Experience

Lesson for Nigeria

Strong national identity

Promote Nigeria above sectional interests

Merit-based institutions

Reward competence and integrity

Respect for diversity

Celebrate cultural differences

Equal opportunity

Ensure fairness for all citizens

Rule of law

Apply justice impartially

Civic education

Build responsible citizenship

### **Lesson Three: Diversity Can Drive Development**

Countries with diverse populations often benefit from multiple perspectives, creativity, entrepreneurship, and innovation.

When diversity is managed fairly:

Businesses become more competitive.

Research becomes more innovative.

Tourism expands.

Cultural industries flourish.

National unity becomes stronger.

Nigeria's cultural richness can become a major source of economic growth if properly harnessed.

### **Lesson Four: Strong Institutions Matter More Than Strong Personalities**

Nations develop when institutions are stronger than individuals.

Independent courts, professional public services, credible electoral bodies, accountable legislatures, and responsible security institutions provide equal protection for all citizens regardless of ethnic background.

Strong institutions reduce the temptation to seek protection through tribal loyalties.

### **Figure 15.1: Foundations of National Unity**

Justice ↓ Strong Institutions ↓ Public Trust ↓ National Unity ↓ Economic Growth ↓ National Prosperity

### **Lesson Five: Education Promotes Unity**

Countries that invest in civic education, history, ethics, leadership development, and cultural understanding often experience greater national cohesion.

Schools should help young people appreciate diversity, reject prejudice, and develop a strong sense of shared citizenship.

Education remains one of the most effective long-term investments in national unity.

### **Lesson Six: Leadership Sets the National Tone**

The attitudes of national leaders influence society.

Leaders who govern fairly, respect diversity, reward merit, and unite citizens inspire confidence and national loyalty.

Conversely, leaders who exploit ethnic differences weaken public trust and deepen divisions.

Leadership therefore carries enormous responsibility in building national unity.

### **What Nigeria Can Do**

Drawing from international experience, Nigeria should continue to:

Strengthen democratic institutions.

Promote merit and equal opportunity.

Improve civic education.

Encourage inter-ethnic cooperation.

Protect the rule of law.

Reward integrity and excellence.

Invest in youth development.

Promote inclusive economic growth.

Encourage dialogue and peaceful conflict resolution.

These actions are consistent with Nigeria's constitutional aspirations and democratic values.

### Reflection Questions

Which international lesson is most relevant to Nigeria today?

How can strong institutions reduce tribalism?

What role do leadership play in promoting national unity?

What lesson can I personally apply in my daily life?

### Practical Exercise

Study one successful multi-ethnic country and identify three policies or practices that could be adapted to strengthen national unity in Nigeria. Discuss your ideas with colleagues, students, or community members and consider how they could be implemented within Nigeria's unique context.

### Chapter Summary

The experiences of other multi-ethnic nations demonstrate that diversity is not an obstacle to development. Countries prosper when they build strong institutions, promote merit, respect diversity, uphold the rule of law, and cultivate a shared national identity.

Nigeria possesses all the human and natural resources necessary to become one of the world's leading nations. By learning from international experience while remaining faithful to its own history and values, Nigeria can build a future in which every citizen is treated with fairness, dignity, and equal opportunity.

Key Thought: "The strongest nations are not those without diversity, but those that transform diversity into unity, strength, and national progress."

The next chapter, Chapter Sixteen: Building the Nigeria of Our Dreams, will present a practical national vision, outlining the responsibilities of government, civil society, the private sector, traditional institutions, and citizens in creating a united, peaceful, just, and prosperous Nigeria.

## CHAPTER SIXTEEN

### BUILDING THE NIGERIA OF OUR DREAMS

#### INTRODUCTION

Every great nation begins as a dream in the minds of patriotic citizens. The Nigeria of our dreams is one where justice prevails over injustice, merit triumphs over favoritism, unity overcomes division, and every citizen has the opportunity to develop his or her God-given talents regardless of ethnic origin, religion, gender, or social background.

Such a Nigeria will not emerge by chance. It must be deliberately built through visionary leadership, responsible citizenship, strong institutions, sound public policies, and unwavering commitment to national unity.

A detribalised Nigerian does not merely complain about the nation's shortcomings; he or she becomes part of the solution.

#### A Shared National Vision

The Nigeria of our dreams is one in which:

Every citizen enjoys equal protection under the law.

Public offices are occupied on the basis of merit, competence, and integrity.

Elections are peaceful, free, and credible.

Diversity is celebrated as a national strength.

Public resources are managed transparently and responsibly.

Every child has access to quality education.

Every community enjoys peace and security.

Opportunities are available to all regardless of ethnicity or religion.

This vision is achievable if citizens and leaders work together.

#### The Responsibilities of Government

Government has a constitutional duty to promote justice, peace, security, and development.

To strengthen national unity, government should:

Uphold the rule of law.

Ensure fairness in public appointments.

Fight corruption consistently.

Invest in education and healthcare.

Strengthen democratic institutions.

Promote inclusive economic growth.

Protect the rights of every citizen.

Encourage national integration through public policies.

When government acts fairly, public confidence increases.

#### Table 16.1: Building the Nigeria of Our Dreams

Stakeholder

## Primary Responsibility

### Government

Justice, security, development

### Citizens

Patriotism and responsible conduct

### Families

Moral upbringing

### Schools

Civic education and national values

### Religious Institutions

Peace and moral leadership

### Traditional Institutions

Community harmony

### Private Sector

Merit and equal opportunity

### Media

Responsible communication

### The Responsibilities of Citizens

Nation-building is not the responsibility of government alone.

Every Nigerian should:

Obey the law.

Reject tribal prejudice.

Promote peaceful coexistence.

Pay lawful civic obligations.

Protect public property.

Vote responsibly.

Support community development.

Defend justice and fairness.

Responsible citizenship is the foundation of a successful democracy.

### The Role of Young People

Nigeria's future depends largely on its youth.

Young Nigerians should:

Pursue education and skills.

Reject violence and hate speech.

Develop entrepreneurial abilities.

Participate constructively in civic life.

Promote innovation and creativity.

Build friendships across ethnic boundaries.

Lead with integrity and patriotism.

The next generation must build upon the lessons of the past rather than repeat its mistakes.

### Figure 16.1: The Path to the Nigeria of Our Dreams

Responsible Citizens ↓ Ethical Leadership ↓ Strong Institutions ↓ National Unity  
↓ Economic Prosperity ↓ Sustainable National Development

### A Call to National Renewal

National renewal begins with personal renewal.

Every Nigerian should commit to:

Speaking respectfully about every ethnic group.

Rejecting corruption and favoritism.

Promoting merit.

Supporting peaceful dialogue.

Helping vulnerable members of society.

Encouraging national rather than sectional thinking.

Serving Nigeria faithfully wherever called.

When millions of citizens adopt these values, national transformation becomes possible.

### Reflection Questions

What kind of Nigeria do I want future generations to inherit?

Which personal habits contribute to national unity?

How can I influence others to become detribalised Nigerians?

What practical contribution can I make to my community during the next year?

### Practical Exercise

Prepare your own Personal National Renewal Plan. List ten practical commitments that you will faithfully observe during the next twelve months to promote fairness, integrity, patriotism, and national unity in your family, workplace, community, and public life. Review your progress every three months.

### Chapter Summary

Building the Nigeria of our dreams requires a partnership between responsible citizens, ethical leaders, strong institutions, families, schools, religious bodies, the media, and the private sector. National unity cannot be achieved through government action alone; it must be strengthened daily by the conduct of ordinary Nigerians.

The dream of a peaceful, united, just, and prosperous Nigeria is within reach if every citizen embraces the values of fairness, integrity, merit, patriotism, and respect for diversity.

Key Thought: "The Nigeria of our dreams will not be inherited—it will be built by citizens who choose unity over division, service over selfishness, and justice over prejudice."

The final chapter, Chapter Seventeen: A Personal Action Plan for Becoming a Detribalised Nigerian, will conclude the book with a practical National Renewal Charter, personal pledges, daily habits, and an inspiring call to action for every Nigerian.

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

### A PERSONAL ACTION PLAN FOR BECOMING A DETRIBALISED NIGERIAN

#### THE NATIONAL RENEWAL CHARTER

#### INTRODUCTION

Every meaningful journey ends with a commitment to action. Throughout this book, we have examined the causes and consequences of tribalism, the qualities of a detribalised Nigerian, and ten practical steps towards becoming a better citizen. Knowledge alone, however, cannot transform a nation. Transformation begins when knowledge is translated into daily action.

Nigeria will become a stronger, more united, and more prosperous nation when millions of ordinary citizens deliberately choose fairness over prejudice, merit over favoritism, dialogue over conflict, and patriotism over sectional loyalty.

This final chapter presents a practical action plan that every Nigerian can adopt, regardless of age, occupation, religion, ethnic background, or political affiliation.

#### My Personal Commitment

As a detribalised Nigerian, I pledge to:

Love Nigeria above ethnic, sectional, or personal interests.

Respect every Nigerian regardless of tribe, language, religion, or place of origin.

Judge people by their character, competence, and integrity.

Reject tribal prejudice, discrimination, and hate speech.

Promote merit and fairness in every decision I make.

Defend justice and equal opportunity for all citizens.

Speak positively about Nigeria and its diversity.

Build friendships across ethnic and religious boundaries.

Resolve disagreements peacefully and respectfully.

Serve my community and my nation faithfully.

#### The National Renewal Charter

To build the Nigeria of our dreams, every citizen should commit to the following principles:

Nigeria comes before tribe.

Character is more important than ethnic origin.

Merit should guide appointments and promotions.

Justice must be available to all.

Public office is a trust for service.

Diversity is a national strength.

Corruption, nepotism, and favoritism must be rejected.

Dialogue is better than violence.

Every Nigerian deserves dignity and respect.

National unity is everyone's responsibility.

These principles form the moral foundation of a detribalised Nigeria.

### **Table 17.1: Daily Habits of a Detribalised Nigerian**

Daily Habit

Positive Result

Respect everyone

Builds trust

Speak responsibly

Promotes peace

Reject discrimination

Encourages fairness

Reward merit

Strengthens institutions

Serve the community

Builds national unity

Learn continuously

Broadens understanding

Resolve conflicts peacefully

Promotes harmony

Demonstrate integrity

Inspires others

Measuring Personal Progress

At the end of every month, ask yourself:

Have I treated everyone fairly?

Did I allow tribal prejudice to influence any decision?

Have I made a new friend from another ethnic group?

Have I corrected false stereotypes when I heard them?

Have I promoted peace in my family, workplace, or community?

What can I improve next month?

True transformation occurs through continuous self-examination and improvement.

### **Figure 17.1: The Cycle of National Renewal**

Personal Change ↓ Family Influence ↓ Community Transformation ↓ National Unity ↓ Good Governance ↓ Prosperity for All

A Message to Young Nigerians

The future of Nigeria belongs to its young people. They have the opportunity to build a nation that is stronger, fairer, and more united than the one they inherited.

Young Nigerians should reject every form of ethnic hatred and embrace:

Excellence.

Innovation.

Patriotism.

Integrity.

Service.

Peaceful coexistence.

Respect for diversity.

They are the architects of tomorrow's Nigeria.

A Final Call to Action

Let every teacher teach unity.

Let every parent raise children without prejudice.

Let every religious leader preach peace and justice.

Let every traditional ruler encourage harmony.

Let every employer reward merit .

Let every politician serve the nation rather than sectional interests.

Let every public servant administer justice fairly.

Above all, let every Nigerian remember that our common humanity and shared citizenship are greater than our differences.

History will judge this generation not by the number of ethnic groups it contained, but by whether it transformed diversity into national strength.

## **CHAPTER SUMMARY**

Becoming a detribalised Nigerian is not an impossible dream. It is a deliberate decision followed by consistent daily action. Every citizen has the power to influence family members, colleagues, neighbours, and future generations through personal example.

The journey begins with one person but spreads from one home to another, from one community to another , and ultimately throughout the nation.

If millions of Nigerians embrace the principles contained in this book, the dream of a peaceful, united, just, and prosperous Nigeria can become a living reality.

Final Inspirational Message

"Nigeria is our common home. Our ethnic identities enrich us, but our shared destiny as Nigerians must unite us. Let us build a nation where justice is stronger than prejudice, merit is greater than favoritism, service is nobler than selfishness, and love for country rises above every dividing line. The future of Nigeria is in our hands, and the time to build that future is now."

## BIBLIOGRAPHY AND REFERENCES

(APA 7th Edition)

### Books

(1983). *The Trouble with Nigeria*. Heinemann.

(1981). *A Political Economy of Africa*. Long man.

(1958). *Nigeria: Background to Nationalism*. University of California Press.

(1988). *Class, Ethnicity and Democracy in Nigeria*. Syracuse University Press.

(1973). *Instability and Political Order: Politics and Crisis in Nigeria*. Ibadan University Press.

(1975). "Colonialism and the Two Publics in Africa." *African Studies Review*, 17(1), 91–112.

& Heaton, M. M. (2008). *A History of Nigeria*. Cambridge University Press.

(1996). *Citizen and Subject*. Princeton University Press.

(1978). *Ethnic Politics in Nigeria*. Fourth Dimension Publishers.

(2001). *Federalism and Ethnic Conflict in Nigeria*. United States Institute of Peace Press.

### Journal Articles

(1993). "The Unique Case of African Democracy." *International Affairs*.

(1995). "The Ogoni Uprising." *African Affairs*.

(1996). "Ethnic Minority Conflicts and Governance in Nigeria." *African Affairs*.

### Government Publications

Federal Republic of Nigeria. (1999, as amended). *Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria*.

Federal Republic of Nigeria. *National Policy on Education* (latest edition).

Federal Republic of Nigeria. *National Youth Policy*.

### International Publications

. *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*.

. *Human Development Reports*.

. *African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights*.

. *World Development Report* (various editions).

. *Publications on Peace Education, Intercultural Dialogue, and Global Citizenship Education*.

### Glossary of Key Terms

**Bias:** A preconceived opinion or preference that affects objective judgment.

**Citizenship:** The legal status and responsibilities of belonging to a nation.

**Civic Responsibility:** Duties owed by citizens to their country and community.

**Detribalisation:** The process of rising above ethnic prejudice and treating all citizens fairly.

**Diversity:** The existence of different ethnic, cultural, linguistic, or religious groups within a society.

**Ethnicity:** Membership of a cultural group sharing common ancestry, language, history, or traditions.

**Federal Character:** A constitutional principle intended to promote equitable representation in Nigeria.

**Good Governance:** Governance characterized by accountability, transparency, participation, effectiveness, and the rule of law.

**Integrity:** Consistent adherence to moral and ethical principles.

**Meritocracy:** Selection and advancement based on ability, competence, and performance.

**National Integration:** The process of strengthening unity among diverse groups within a country.

**Nepotism:** Giving unfair preference to relatives in appointments or opportunities.

**Patriotism:** Love, loyalty, and commitment to one's country.

**Rule of Law:** The principle that everyone is subject to the law equally.

**Social Cohesion:** The ability of members of a society to live together peacefully and cooperatively.

**Stereotype:** An oversimplified belief about a particular group of people.

**Tolerance:** Respecting and accepting differences without discrimination.

**Tribalism:** Excessive loyalty to one's ethnic group at the expense of national unity.

Egonmwan, J. A. Principles of Public Administration in Context.

Egonmwan, J. A. Comparative Public Administration.

Egonmwan, J. A. Development Administration: Theory and Practice.

Egonmwan, J. A. Public Policy Analysis: Concepts and Applications.

Egonmwan, J. A. Control and Accountability for Development Results in Public Administration.

Egonmwan, J. A. The Anatomy of Corruption in Emerging Democracies.

Egonmwan, J. A. Rich Nation, Poor People.

Egonmwan, J. A. Organizational Behaviour, Leadership and Human Resources Management.

Egonmwan, J. A. e-Government: Issues, Approaches and Prospects.

Egonmwan, J. A. Stress: The Silent Killer —Detection and Management.

Egonmwan, J. A. Empowered to Rise.

Egonmwan, J. A. Event Management in Nigeria: A Practical Guide.

Egonmwan, J. A. Capacity to Impact.

Egonmwan, J. A. Making Party Democracy Work in Nigeria.